

British computer scientist Tim Berners-Lee invented the World Wide Web—now a multimedia library, workplace, and shopping and social space that can be accessed via the internet. He set it up in 1991 and gave it to the world for free.

MILESTONES

EARLY PROGRAM

Writes ENQUIRE in 1980, a computer program to connect CERN academics and their projects.

LANDMARK PAPER

Submits "Information Management: A Proposal" in 1989, outlining a linked hypertext data system.

WORLD WIDE WEB

Launches the World Wide Web at CERN in 1991, including HTML, HTTP, and the first browser.

RECEIVES KNIGHTHOOD

Knighted in 2004 by Queen Elizabeth II for services to the global development of the internet.

Born in London in 1955, Tim Berners-Lee was interested in computers from an early age. His parents met at UK company Ferranti, where they worked as computer programmers on the Mark I, the world's first general-purpose business computer. Berners-Lee went to Oxford University in 1973 to study physics, and while he was there, he built his first homemade computer using a second-hand television, some logic gates, and a processor.

After graduating, Berners-Lee worked as a software engineer for British companies before joining CERN—Europe's nuclear research lab, now best known as the home of the Large Hadron Collider—as a consultant in 1980. It was while grappling with the communication demands of the international laboratory's multilingual staff that he hit on the idea that would transform the way the world communicates.

Connecting the world

In 1980, Berners-Lee wrote ENQUIRE, a program that could store information and track the connections between people and projects at CERN. Although it only existed on Berners-Lee's computer, ENQUIRE demonstrated that the documents collected on the internet—a physical network of computers that had been growing steadily since its origins in 1963—could one day be accessed by anyone with a computer. Largely promoted by academics and the US Department of

Tim Berners-Lee's vision of "universal access to a large universe of documents" has been far exceeded, yet his dream of an open, democratic Web has been threatened by growing political and commercial interests online.

